In exploring how IOs navigate such issues, we build on and extend foundational scholarship on the liberal order and its discontents (Borzel and Zürn 2021; Farrell and Newman 2021; Weiss and Wallace 2021). By focusing on the agency of IOs and their ability to pursue their goals even when those goals conflict with member-state preferences (Vaubel 1991; Johnson 2014; Clark and Zucker 2024), we illuminate the practical realities of global governance in an age of upheaval. Ultimately, this work underscores the stakes of understanding IOs not just as facilitators of cooperation, but as actors navigating a turbulent political landscape. By theorizing and testing how IOs defend themselves, we provide a road map for preserving the liberal order in the face of unprecedented threats, offering critical insights into the future of international cooperation.

1.7.2 Empirical

This project makes several important empirical contributions, shedding new light on how IOs respond to populist challenges and supplying scholars with valuable data to explore related questions in future research. By documenting how IOs use appeasement and sidelining strategies to counter populists, we reveal the creative and often underappreciated ways these organizations maintain their relevance and authority. To accomplish this, we collected and analyzed several novel datasets.

One such contribution lies in the use of a unique data source: Grays, or written submissions by states filed ahead of IMF board meetings. Secretive interactions between states and IOs are notoriously difficult to study because of their inherent opacity. Yet these submissions provide an unprecedented glimpse into behind-the-scenes diplomacy: Grays remain confidential for years after their initial filing (Carnegie, Clark, and Kaya 2024). Our analysis reveals that populist leaders—despite their public antagonism toward the IMF—engage covertly with the organization more frequently than their nonpopulist counterparts. These findings not only enrich our understanding of populist behavior but also offer a valuable resource for future studies on covert diplomacy in international relations.

We also conducted an original survey experiment on a diverse sample of Americans to examine how IOs might engage skeptical domestic audiences. Drawing inspiration from real-world IO rhetoric, identified through elite